



**Upper hand:** Praggnanandhaa believes his teammate and fellow Grandmaster, D. Gukesh, will be the favourite in this year's World Championship match against Ding Liren. FIDE/LENNART OOTES

tournaments with and without her, so I'm used to both situations.

**Chess training can be expensive. How has your sponsorship with Adani Sportslines helped you?**

Their support has been crucial. Chess can be an expensive sport, especially when it comes to training and competing abroad. Working with foreign coaches costs a lot. The Adani Group has provided vital financial support, especially during the Candidates, by helping with the expenses for foreign trainers. Thanks to them, I don't have to worry about the financial aspect and can focus entirely on my game.

**What are your thoughts on**

**franchise-based leagues like the Global Chess League (GCL)? Do you enjoy the format?**

It's a great concept and perfectly timed. Chess is growing, and the league adds excitement for fans. Last year's tournament was thrilling, with two dominant teams missing out on the finals. The final itself was dramatic, coming down to sudden death. It showed that chess can be marketed as a fan-friendly sport. I really enjoyed playing in the GCL last year, and I'm looking forward to more excitement this year.

**The GCL awards an extra point for winning with Black. How do you feel about the dynamics this adds to the game?**

The format is unique and exciting. Winning with Black can completely change a match, which is rare in other formats. I remember one of our matches last year—it was incredibly tense. We lost two games with Black, and there were two draws. Then I won my game, and the

legendary match between Anand and Sir and Magnus turned everything around. It was chaotic, but in a good way, making the tournament much more exciting.

**How was your experience playing with Magnus Carlsen in U Mumba? What did you learn from him and your other teammates?**

It was an amazing experience. I had the opportunity to discuss chess with him during team meetings, dinners and even some training games. It wasn't just beneficial for me but also for Arjun (Erigaisi) and Gukesh. This year will be interesting too, especially with Richard Rapport in the team. He's a very creative player, and I'd like to see how he thinks — I might even incorporate some of his ideas into my own game.

**Do you think India can dominate team chess events like the Olympiad in the future?**

Absolutely. We are a strong force in team events. In the coming years,